

FREE GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

Software Project Planning Guide

A practical playbook for founders and business leaders: how to plan a website, app or custom software project that ships on time, on budget — and actually grows your business.

Why most software projects go over budget

Most projects don't fail because of bad code. They fail because of unclear goals, scope that keeps growing, and decisions made too late. The good news: all three are planning problems — and planning is cheap compared to rework.

Common cause	What it looks like	The fix (in this guide)
No measurable goal	"We need a new website" with no target	Step 1 — Define outcomes
Scope creep	Features added every week	Step 2 — Scope an MVP
Unrealistic budget	Price decided before scope	Step 3 — Budget & timeline
Wrong technology	Rebuilt in 18 months	Step 4 — Choose your stack
Vendor mismatch	Missed deadlines, poor communication	Step 5 — Pick a partner
"Launch and forget"	Traffic but no results	Step 6 — Launch & grow

How to use this guide: work through the six steps in order and tick the checklists. By the end you'll have a one-page project brief any development partner can quote accurately against.

STEP 1

Define outcomes, not features

Start with the business result you need in 12 months. Features come later — and only if they move that number.

- ☐ Write one sentence: "In 12 months this project will ___ (metric) from ___ to ___."
- ☐ List your primary users (customers, staff, partners) and their #1 job to be done.
- ☐ Note what happens today without the software — the cost of doing nothing.
- ☐ Agree who makes final decisions, and how fast.

Example: "Increase online appointment bookings from 40 to 150 per month, and cut phone-booking time for reception by 50%."

STEP 2

Scope a Minimum Viable Product

An MVP is the smallest version that delivers the outcome to real users. Sort every idea into three buckets:

Must have (launch)	Should have (v1.1)	Could have (later)
Without it, the outcome is impossible	Valuable, but users can cope for 2–3 months	Nice ideas — revisit with real data

- ☐ No more than 5–7 "must have" features.
- ☐ Each must-have is traced to the outcome from Step 1.
- ☐ Sketch the key screens — even on paper. Pictures remove ambiguity.

STEP 3

Set a realistic budget & timeline

Budget follows scope — never the other way round. Use these typical ranges as a sanity check:

Project type	Typical timeline	Main cost drivers
Business website	4–8 weeks	Pages, content, integrations, CMS
E-commerce store	8–14 weeks	Catalogue size, payments, logistics
Mobile app MVP	10–16 weeks	Platforms, backend, offline needs
Custom business software	12–24 weeks	Workflows, roles, data migration

- ☐ Reserve 15–20% contingency for discoveries during development.
- ☐ Budget for year one after launch: hosting, maintenance and improvements (~15–25% of build).
- ☐ Plan content (copy, images, data) — it's the most common cause of delay.

STEP 4

Choose technology for the next 5 years

Ask these questions

- ☐ Can we hire developers for it in 3 years?
- ☐ Will it handle 10× today's users?
- ☐ Can our team edit content without a developer?
- ☐ Does it integrate with our CRM / ERP / payments?

Proven, mainstream choices

Web: Next.js / React, Node.js

Mobile: React Native or Flutter

Data: MongoDB, MySQL / PostgreSQL

Content: headless CMS or WordPress

Immersive: Three.js / WebXR

STEP 5

Choose a partner, not a vendor

The cheapest quote often becomes the most expensive project. Compare partners on how they'll reduce your risk:

- ☐ They asked about your business goals before talking about technology.
- ☐ They showed relevant case studies with measurable results.
- ☐ You'll see working software every 1–2 weeks, not only at the end.
- ☐ You own the code, designs and accounts from day one.
- ☐ Support, hosting and handover are defined in writing.

STEP 6

Launch — then grow

Launch day is the start of learning, not the finish line.

Launch checklist

- ☐ Analytics & conversion tracking live
- ☐ Speed: pages load in under 3 seconds on mobile
- ☐ SEO basics: titles, sitemap, redirects
- ☐ Backups, monitoring and security updates

First 90 days

- ☐ Review the Step 1 metric every 2 weeks
- ☐ Fix the top 3 drop-off points in your funnel
- ☐ Ship the "should have" list in priority order
- ☐ Collect user feedback before new features

Project brief template

Fill this in and send it to any development partner — you'll get faster, more accurate quotes.

Section	Your answer
Business outcome (Step 1)	
Primary users & their main task	
Must-have features (max 7)	
Integrations (CRM, payments, ERP...)	
Budget range & target launch date	
Decision maker & review cadence	

Want a second opinion on your plan?

Book a free 30-minute consultation with Riyadvi — we'll review your brief and suggest the fastest path to results. Or take the free Business Health Checkup at riyadvsoftwaretechnologies.com.